“Śrī Caitanya-caritāmṛta”

Antya-līlā

Chapter 16

Śrī Caitanya Tastes the Nectar of Kṛṣṇa’s Lips

(translated from the Bengali for this edition)

1 I bow down to Śrī Kṛṣṇa Caitanya, who Himself tasted the nectar of love for Kṛṣṇa and made His devotees taste it; so He taught them initiation into *prema*.

2 Glory, glory to Śrī Caitanya! Glory to Nityānanda! Glory to Advaitacandra, and glory to all the devotees of Gaura!

3 In this way Mahāprabhu lived in Nīlācala with His devotees, always overwhelmed by love.

4 The next year all the devotees of Gauḍa came again and, as before, met the Lord.

5 With them came a devotee named Kālidāsa, who knew nothing but the name of Kṛṣṇa.

6 He was a great devotee, simple and generous, and he conducted all his dealings with the name of Kṛṣṇa as his signal.

7 If he played at dice for fun, he would throw the dice saying, “Hare Kṛṣṇa! Hare Kṛṣṇa!”

8 He was an uncle of Raghunātha dāsa by kinship, and he grew old eating the remnants of Vaiṣṇavas.

9 He ate the remnants of all the Vaiṣṇavas there were in Gauḍa.

10 To all the Vaiṣṇavas of brāhmaṇa birth, small and great, he would go with the finest things as gifts.

11 From them he would beg the plates with their remnants; where he did not get them, he would stay hidden nearby.

12 When a Vaiṣṇava had eaten and thrown away his plate, he would secretly bring that plate and lick it clean.

13 He went with gifts to the homes of Vaiṣṇavas of śūdra birth too, and in the same way secretly ate their remnants.

14 There was a Vaiṣṇava named Jhaḍu, of the *bhūṅimāli* caste. Kālidāsa went to his home, taking mangoes.

15 He offered him the mangoes, bowed at his feet, and then offered obeisance to his wife.

16 Jhaḍu was sitting with his wife; seeing Kālidāsa, he received him with great respect.

17 After talking with him a while, Jhaḍu Ṭhākura said to him sweetly:

18 “I am of low birth, and you are a most honored guest. How shall I serve you?

19 Give me leave to take provisions to a brāhmaṇa’s house. There you can take *prasāda*, and then I shall live.”

20 Kālidāsa said, “Ṭhākura, be merciful to me! I, a fallen sinner, have come to see you.

21 By seeing you I have become pure. My purpose is fulfilled, and my life has borne its fruit.

22 I have one desire, if you will be merciful: give me the dust of your feet, and place your foot on my head.”

23 The Ṭhākura said, “It is not fitting to say such things. I am of low birth, and you are a noble gentleman.”

24 Then Kālidāsa recited verses for him, and hearing them, Jhaḍu Ṭhākura was greatly pleased.

25 “Even a knower of the four Vedas is not dear to Me if he is not devoted to Me, but My devotee is dear to Me even if he was born a dog-eater. One should give to him and accept from him; he is to be worshipped just as I am.” (Itihāsa-samuccaya, quoted in Hari-bhakti-vilāsa, 10.91)

26 “I consider a dog-eater whose mind, words, deeds, wealth and very life are offered to the Lord of the lotus navel better than a brāhmaṇa endowed with the twelve qualities who has turned away from His lotus feet. Such a devotee purifies his whole family; the brāhmaṇa swollen with pride cannot.” (Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam, 7.9.10)

27 “Oh, how wonderful! Even a dog-eater is worthy of the highest honour if Your name is on the tip of his tongue. Those who utter Your name have already performed austerities and offered sacrifices; they have bathed in all the holy waters, they are truly noble, and they have studied the Vedas.” (Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam, 3.33.7)

28 Hearing this, the Ṭhākura said, “What scripture says is true: one in whom there is devotion to Kṛṣṇa is not low.[1]

29 But I am of low birth, and I have no devotion to Kṛṣṇa. Others may be such, but I have no such power.”

30 Bowing to him, Kālidāsa asked leave to go, and Jhaḍu Ṭhākura walked after him to see him off.

31 When the Ṭhākura had seen him off and returned home, Kālidāsa went to the place where his footprints lay.

32 Kālidāsa took that dust and smeared it all over his body, and then he hid near Jhaḍu’s house.

33 On reaching home Jhaḍu Ṭhākura saw the mangoes and offered them all to Kṛṣṇacandra within his mind.

34 His wife took the mangoes out of the banana leaves and bark in which they were wrapped and handed them to him, and he sucked them.

35 He sucked them and threw the sucked stones into the wrappings. When she had fed him, his wife ate afterwards.

36 She filled those wrappings with the sucked stones, took them out, and threw them into the pit for leftovers.

37 Kālidāsa sucked those wrappings, stones and skins, and as he sucked them he was jubilant with love.

38 In this way Kālidāsa took the remnants of all the Vaiṣṇavas who lived in the land of Gauḍa.

39 When this Kālidāsa came to Nīlācala, Mahāprabhu showed him great mercy.

40 Every day, when the Lord went to see Lord Jagannātha, Govinda went with Him carrying His waterpot.

41 On the north side of the Siṁha-dvāra, behind the door panel, at the foot of the twenty-two steps, there was a low pit.

42 In that pit the Lord would wash His feet, and then He would go to see the Lord.

43 Mahāprabhu had given Govinda a rule: “See that no one takes the water that washes My feet.”

44 No living being could take that water; only intimate devotees took it, on one pretext or another.

45 One day, as the Lord was washing His feet there, Kālidāsa came and held out his cupped hands.

46 He drank one palmful, two palmfuls, three palmfuls, and then Mahāprabhu stopped him:

47 “From now on, do not do this again. Thus far I have fulfilled your desire.”

48 Caitanya, the Lord, the crest jewel of the omniscient, knew Kālidāsa’s heart and his faith in Vaiṣṇavas.

49 Pleased with him for that quality, the Lord showed him a mercy rarely granted to others.

50 Behind the twenty-two steps, above them on the south side, to the left as one goes up, is a Deity of Lord Nṛsiṁha.

51 Every day the Lord bowed down to Him and, bowing, recited this verse again and again:

52 “Obeisance to You, Lord Narasiṁha, who give joy to Prahlāda, and whose nails are a chisel on the stone of Hiraṇyakaśipu’s chest.” (Nṛsiṁha-purāṇa)

53 “Nṛsiṁha is here, Nṛsiṁha is there; wherever I go, there is Nṛsiṁha. Nṛsiṁha is outside, Nṛsiṁha is in the heart. I take shelter of Nṛsiṁha, the original Lord.” (Nṛsiṁha-purāṇa)

54 Then the Lord took *darśana* of Jagannātha, and coming home, He took His midday meal.

55 Kālidāsa was waiting hopefully at the outer door. Knowing this, the Lord gave Govinda a sign.

56 Govinda understood all the Lord’s signs, and he gave Kālidāsa the Lord’s plate of remnants.

57 Such is the greatness of eating the remnants of Vaiṣṇavas: it brought Kālidāsa the utmost limit of the Lord’s mercy.

58 Therefore, giving up disgust and shame, eat the leftovers (*jhuṭā*) of Vaiṣṇavas; through them you will obtain all you desire.

59 The remnants of Kṛṣṇa are called *mahā-prasāda*; when they become the remnants of a devotee, they are called *mahā-mahā-prasāda*.

60 The dust of a devotee's feet, the water that has washed his feet, and the remnants of what he has eaten — these three are the strength of spiritual practice.

61 By serving these three one attains love for Kṛṣṇa; all the scriptures declare this loudly again and again.

62 Therefore I say again and again: listen, devotees! Serve these three with faith.

63 From these three come the jubilation of Kṛṣṇa's name and of love for Him, and Kṛṣṇa's grace. Kālidāsa is the witness to this.

64 In this way Mahāprabhu lived in Nīlācala, and without anyone noticing He showed Kālidāsa great mercy.

65 That year Śivānanda came with his wife and brought with him his youngest son, Purī dāsa.

66 Taking his son, he came to the Lord and had the boy bow at the Lord's feet.

67 Again and again the Lord said, "Say 'Kṛṣṇa'!" But the boy would not utter the name of Kṛṣṇa.

68 Śivānanda tried hard with the boy, but still he did not say the name of Kṛṣṇa.

69 The Lord said, "I have made the whole world take the name; I have made even the unmoving creatures say the name of Kṛṣṇa.

70 Yet this boy I could not make say the name of Kṛṣṇa!" Hearing this, Svarūpa Gosāñi said:

71 “You have instructed him in the mantra of Kṛṣṇa’s name. Having received the mantra, he will not disclose it before anyone.

72 He chants it within his mind but does not utter it aloud. This, I guess, is what is in his mind.”

73 Another day the Lord said, “Recite, Purī dāsa!” and the boy composed and recited this verse:

74 “Glory to Hari, the complete ornament of the beautiful girls of Vṛndāvana: a blue lotus for their ears, collyrium for their eyes, a garland of great sapphires for their breasts!” (Āryā-śataka, 1)

75 He was a child of seven, who had not studied, yet he composed such a verse! Everyone was amazed.

76 Such is the greatness of Caitanya Prabhu’s mercy; even Brahmā and the other gods cannot find its limit.

77 The devotees stayed with the Lord for four months; then the Lord gave them leave, and they all went back to Gauḍa.

78 In their company the Lord kept His external awareness, but when they had gone, His divine madness again prevailed.

79 Night and day Kṛṣṇa’s form, fragrance and taste appeared to Him; He experienced them directly, as if Kṛṣṇa were touching Him.

80 One day, when the Lord went to see Jagannātha, the doorkeeper came up to Him at the Siṁha-dvāra and bowed down.

81 The Lord said to him, “Where is Kṛṣṇa, the Lord of My life? Show Me Kṛṣṇa!” — and He took his hand.

82 The doorkeeper said, “The son of the king of Vraja is here. Come with me and I will show Him to You.”

83 “You are My friend. Show Me where the Lord of My life is!” Saying this, the Lord went into the *jagamohana*, holding the man’s hand.

84 The doorkeeper said, “Here is Śrī Puruṣottama. Look at Him to Your eyes’ content.”

85 Standing behind the Garuḍa pillar, the Lord gazed, and He saw that Jagannātha was Kṛṣṇa with the flute at His lips.

86 Raghunātha dāsa has described this pastime in his own book, the *Caitanya-stava-kalpavṛkṣa*:

87 “‘Where is My beloved Kṛṣṇa? Friend, you alone can show Him to Me — show Him to Me here, quickly!’ So, as if mad, Gaurāṅga spoke to the doorkeeper; and when he answered, ‘Go quickly to see Your Beloved!’, He took hold of his hand. That Gaurāṅga, rising in my heart, makes me mad with joy.” (Caitanya-stava-kalpavṛkṣa, 7)

88 At that time the *gopāla-vallabha* offering was placed before Jagannātha, and the *ārati* began to the sound of conchshells, bells and other instruments.

89 When the offering was over, Jagannātha’s servants came to the Lord with *prasāda*.

90 Placing a garland on Him, they put the *prasāda* into the Lord’s hands. Let alone its taste — its very fragrance intoxicated the mind.

91 That *prasāda* was very precious, made of the finest things, and the servant tried his best to have the Lord eat a little of it.

92 The Lord took a little of it and put it on His tongue; all the rest He tied in the end of Govinda's cloth.

93 Tasting what was sweeter than millions of nectars, the Lord was struck with wonder. His hair stood on end all over His body, and streams of tears flowed from His eyes.

94 "Where has such taste in this food come from? The nectar of Kṛṣṇa's lips must have entered it."

95 At this thought Mahāprabhu was overcome by love, but seeing Jagannātha's servant, He restrained Himself.

96 Again and again He said, "A particle of the remnants, gained by *sukṛti*!" The servant of the Lord asked, "What does this mean?"

97 The Lord said, "What you have given Me is the nectar of Kṛṣṇa's lips. Even Brahmā and the gods can hardly obtain it, and it puts nectar itself to shame.

98 The remnants of what Kṛṣṇa has eaten are called *phelā*. Whoever obtains even a particle of it is fortunate.

99 It cannot be attained by ordinary good fortune. Only one on whom Kṛṣṇa's full mercy rests obtains it.

100 The word *sukṛti* means the piety that is the cause of Kṛṣṇa's mercy. Whoever has it obtains *phelā* and is blessed."

101 Having said this, the Lord bade them all farewell, and after seeing the *upala-bhoga* offering He returned to His residence.

102 He performed His midday duties and finished His meal, but all the while He remembered the nectar of Kṛṣṇa's lips within His heart.

103 He carried out His outward duties, but His mind was overflowing with love; His absorption was intense, and He restrained it only with great difficulty.

104 After His evening duties He again sat in seclusion with His own associates, delighting in many talks about Kṛṣṇa.

105 At the Lord's sign Govinda brought the *prasāda*, and the Lord sent some to Paramānanda Purī and Brahmānanda Bhāratī.

106 He divided the *prasāda* and gave it to all — Rāmānanda, Sārvabhauma, Svarūpa and the others.

107 When they tasted the fragrance and sweetness of the *prasāda*, everyone was amazed at its unearthly taste.

108–109 The Lord said, "All these are material substances — sugar, camphor, black pepper, cardamom, cloves, ghee, spices, cinnamon and the rest. Everyone knows the taste of material things.

110 Yet these substances have a taste and a fragrance beyond this world. Taste them and see for yourselves.

111 Let alone its taste — its fragrance alone intoxicates the mind and makes one forget every sweetness but its own.

112 Therefore Kṛṣṇa's lips must have touched this food, and all the qualities of His lips have passed into it.

113 An unearthly fragrance and taste, and the power to make one forget everything else — such are the greatly intoxicating qualities of Kṛṣṇa's lips.

114 This has been obtained by great *sukṛti*. All of you, taste it with great devotion."

115 Calling out "Hari!", they all tasted it, and as they tasted it their minds grew mad with love.

116 When Mahāprabhu, absorbed in love, gave the order, Rāmānanda Rāya began to recite verses.

117 "O hero, bestow on us the nectar of Your lips, which increases the longing for union and destroys grief; which is kissed so well by Your sounding flute and makes men forget all other attachments." (Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam, 10.31.14)

118 Hearing the verse, Mahāprabhu was greatly pleased, and He began to recite a verse of Rādhā's longing:

119 "O friend, the shining nectar of His lips takes away the thirst for every other taste from the incomparable noble ladies of Vraja; a particle of His remnants is gained only by *sukṛti*; He chews rolls of fine betel leaves that surpass nectar. That Madana-mohana of Mine increases the craving of My tongue." (Govinda-līlāmṛta, 8.8)

120 Having said this, Gaura Prabhu, absorbed in feeling, explained the meaning of the two verses in His raving (*pralāpa*).

121–122 "O lover, hear the conduct of Your lips! They stir the body and mind, increase the longing for union, and take away the burden of joy, grief and all the rest. They make one forget every other taste, bring the whole world under their sway, and destroy shame, duty and composure. They in-

toxicate the minds of women and draw their tongues to them. Yet on reflection, everything about them is contrary.

123 Let alone women — I am ashamed even to say it: Your lips are a very bold lord. They attract even a man, wish to give themselves to him to drink, and make him forget every other taste.

124 Let alone the conscious — they make even the unconscious conscious. Your lips are a great magician! Your flute is only dry wood, yet they create senses and a mind in it and constantly give themselves to it to drink.

125 The flute, a bold man, drinks and drinks the lips of a man and announces its drinking to the gopīs: ‘Oh, hear, gopīs! I am drinking your wealth by force. If you take pride in its being yours,

126 then be angry with me, give up shame, fear and duty — and I will let it go: come and drink. Otherwise I will drink it constantly. I have no fear of you, and I regard others as straw.’

127 Mixing the nectar of Your lips with its own sound, by that power the flute draws the people of the three worlds. And if we, fearing for our duty, try to keep our composure, it makes a mockery of us.

128 Before our elders it loosens the knots at our waists and makes us abandon shame and duty. As if seizing us by the hair, it leads us away, brings us to You and makes us Your maidservants, and people laugh to hear of it. In this way it makes women dance.

129 A stick of dry bamboo heaps such insults on us! Like a master, it has brought us to this state. What can we do but bear it? So we keep silent: when a thief is punished, his mother cannot call out and weep.

130 Such is the way of Your lips. Hear now their bad custom: whatever meets those lips — food to chew, food to eat, or drink — becomes like nectar, and it is called ‘Kṛṣṇa’s *phelā*.’

131 All the gods together cannot obtain a particle of that *phelā* — who would believe such a boast? One performs pious acts for many births; then it is called *sukṛti*, and by that *sukṛti* one obtains a particle of it.

132 The betel Kṛṣṇa chews is said to be beyond price. On top of that comes this artful boast: what He has chewed they call ‘the essence of nectar,’ and they make the gopīs’ mouths its spittoon.

133 All this is Your trickery. Give up this artfulness! Why do You steal our lives with Your flute? Do not, for Your own amusement, make Yourself guilty of killing women. Give us the gift of the nectar of Your lips.”

134 As He spoke, the Lord’s mood changed: His angry mind grew calm, and His longing increased.

135 “This nectar of Kṛṣṇa’s lips is supremely rare. Whoever obtains it has made his life a success.

136 If someone worthy cannot drink it and still clings to life, he is shameless and lives in vain.

137 Someone unworthy drinks it always, while the worthy one does not get it and only dies of longing.

138 So I know that the power of some austerity gives the unworthy the fruit of Kṛṣṇa’s lip-nectar.

139 Speak, Rāmānanda Rāya! My mind wants to hear something.” Knowing the Lord’s mood, Rāmānanda Rāya recited the words of the

gopīs:

140 “O gopīs, what good deed did this flute perform, that it enjoys by itself the nectar of Dāmodara’s lips, which belongs to the gopīs, leaving only a taste of it behind? The rivers that nourished it thrill with joy, their lotuses like hair standing on end, and the trees shed tears, like elders of a family rejoicing in a descendant.” (Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam, 10.21.9)

141 Hearing this verse, the Lord became absorbed in feeling, and in His longing He explained its meaning in raving words.

142 “Ah, the son of the king of Vraja will certainly marry some maidens of Vraja. By that relation the gopīs know this nectar as their own wealth, and it is not for others to attain.

143 O gopīs, think it over together and tell Me: what holy place, what austerity, what chanting of a perfect mantra did this flute perform in a former birth?

144 Such is the nectar of Kṛṣṇa’s lips: it has eclipsed nectar itself, and only in the hope of it do the gopīs keep their lives. Yet this flute, utterly unworthy, an unmoving thing, and of the male sex besides, drinks that nectar all the time.

145 Without asking those to whom this wealth belongs, it drinks it by force and loudly calls them to come and drink. See the fruit of its austerity, the power of its good fortune: even the great partake of its remnants.

146 The Mānasa-gaṅgā and the Kālindī are rivers that purify the world. When Kṛṣṇa bathes in them, they are overpowered by longing and joyfully drink the taste of His lips left over by the flute.

147 But let alone the rivers! The trees on their banks perform austerities and do good to others; yet they take the taste the rivers have left, draw it up through their roots and drink it — why, I cannot understand.[2]

148 Their new shoots are their hair standing on end, their flowers are blossoming laughter, and in the guise of honey streams of tears flow from them. They regard the flute as their own kin and are transformed by bliss, as a noble man is when his sons and grandsons become Vaiṣṇavas.

149 When we know what austerity the flute performed, we will perform the same. It is unworthy, and we are worthy women. We are dying of grief for want of what the unworthy one drinks, and we cannot bear it. That is why we are pondering its austerity."

150 Thus Gaurahari lamented, absorbed in love, with Svarūpa and Rāmānanda Rāya at His side. Sometimes He danced, sometimes He sang, and sometimes, overcome by feeling, He fell into a swoon. In this way His nights and days passed.

151 Placing on my head the holy feet of Svarūpa, Rūpa, Sanātana and Raghunātha, and hoping for their mercy, I, Kṛṣṇadāsa, lowly and fallen, sing the *Caitanya-caritāmṛta*, a nectar surpassing nectar.

Notes

1. So in the Gauḍīya Maṭha edition: *śāstra ei satya haya / sei nīca nahe, — yāṅte kṛṣṇa-bhakti kaya*. Other editions read *śāstra ei satya kaya / sei śreṣṭha, aiche yāṅte kṛṣṇa-bhakti haya*, "the scriptures speak this truth: the best is one in whom there is devotion to Kṛṣṇa." ↩
2. So in the Gauḍīya Maṭha edition: *e-ta nadī rahu dūre*, "let alone the rivers". Other editions read *e-ta nārī bahu dūre*, "let alone women". ↩